

You are what you eat, they say. And Indians are spoilt for choice when it comes to variety in cuisine. The consequences of that gastronomic wealth are beginning to tell on their bodies. Lifestyle diseases have reached alarming levels in the country. A recent study by the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) confirmed a truth we have known for some time: India is now the diabetes capital of the world. There are more than 101 million people with diabetes and another 136 million who are pre-diabetic. Indians now account for 17 per cent of the diabetics in the world. The culprit is no stranger: it is the sugar in most of the food we eat.

There is more bad news. In an irony that is anything but delicious, a third of Indian infants suffer from malnutrition, yet obesity is assuming epidemic proportions in India. The National Family Health Survey (NFHS)-5 discovered that a whopping 60 per cent of women and 50 per cent of men in urban areas suffer from a substantially high-risk waist-to-hip ratio, an indicator of abdominal obesity. Its natural corollary: hypertension and coronary ailments. Trouble is, they are afflicting young and middle-aged Indians, as *The Lancet* reveals, warning that over a fourth of the deaths in India are now on account of cardiovascular diseases, a rate that has shot up in the past two decades. "The rise in non-communicable diseases like diabetes and heart issues, especially among the young, is a clear sign that Indians are not eating right," says Dr Alka Mohan, former head of dietetics and chief dietitian at AIIMS, New Delhi.

At the same time, Mohan has observed an interesting phenomenon. "While there is an increase in unhealthy eating habits," she says, "the interest in how to eat right is also growing." The growing interest in eating right is validated by the State of Snacking study that Mondelez India conducted among 253 respondents in 2022. The study found that 95 per cent of them were keen to eat products with health qualities in the future, higher than the global average of 87 per cent. According to a report by Avendus Capital, the investment banking arm of the Avendus Group, India is the



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